

Pre-Market Checklist

The exact routine professional traders follow before the market opens every day.

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What you do before the market opens determines the quality of your trading day. A structured pre-market routine eliminates reactive decision-making, keeps you focused on your best setups, and ensures you never enter the open unprepared.

6:00 – 7:00 AM

Overnight Review

Check overnight futures (ES, NQ). Look at any major gap up or gap down. Read news headlines for anything that moved markets overnight. Note the pre-market high and low on your key watchlist names.

7:00 – 8:00 AM

News and Catalysts

Check your news sources for stocks with significant pre-market volume. Look for earnings, FDA decisions, analyst upgrades or downgrades, and any sector-moving news.

8:00 – 9:00 AM

Build Your Watchlist

Narrow your scans down to 3-5 names maximum. For each name, identify: the key level, your entry trigger, your stop, and your target. Know the plan before the bell.

9:00 – 9:30 AM

Final Prep

Check the VIX. Check SPY and QQQ pre-market levels. Set your alerts. Review your game plan one final time. Do not adjust your plan after the open unless the thesis changes entirely.

DAILY PRE-MARKET TEMPLATE — PRINT AND USE

Fill this out every morning before the open.

Date

Futures direction (ES / NQ) — gap up or down? How much?

Key economic data releasing today

VIX level — how does this affect my aggression today?

SPY / QQQ pre-market level and direction

WATCHLIST — TOP 3 TO 5 NAMES

TICKER	CATALYST	KEY LEVEL	ENTRY TRIGGER	STOP	TARGET

Game plan for today — what is my focus? What will I avoid?

TST RULE

Most retail traders open their platform at 9:29 AM with no plan. You will not be one of them. Consistency in your pre-market routine is a competitive edge that compounds over time.

Full pre-market prep methodology taught in the TST Academy Intermediate section at topstocktrading.com